

it contains. Firebug also comes equipped with a nice GUI, which usually sits silently in the background and on the click of a button, comes to the foreground and starts providing useful information to the developers. It is possible to extend Firebug by calling its API library, and to enhance its features as a customisation effort.

The latest version of Firebug has advanced features such as editing CSS templates and adding attributes in real time, and viewing their effect on the Web page, dynamically. The developer can leverage this feature to try all style sheet combinations, check their effect on the user experience, ensure accuracy and then, accordingly, make changes in their release codes. This is a great help when trying out various style sheet objects such as table widths, foreground and background colours, fonts, etc. The newer versions can also help in object stack tracing for advanced developers.

The Firebug interface itself is very user friendly. Based on the nature of the code being developed and debugged, it is possible to instruct Firebug to only show certain types of errors, such as errors for only CSS code, or only for JavaScript, etc. This helps to avoid the clutter and results in quick debugging and faster development.

Installation

While there are no strict pre-requisites for Firebug installation, the computer must have the Firefox browser installed, preferably the latest version. It is important to ensure that no previous installations of Firebug are present, and if they are, they should be removed.

The latest version of Firebug can be downloaded from getfirebug.com/downloads and installed. Upon installation, it is advisable to close all browser instances and restart the browser.

Using Firebug

Firebug can be opened in any one of the following three ways—by clicking on the icon on the right hand side of your browser's navigation bar; by using a shortcut key (default : F12), or by right-clicking the mouse button and selecting 'Inspect element with Firebug'. You can open it in a new window by clicking 'Open firebug in new window',

i.e., the maximise button or as a bar at the bottom of your browser. This opens up a Firebug panel dashboard, which typically occupies the bottom half of the screen. Please refer to Figure 1, which shows a sample dashboard.

Now let's look at how to use this panel for debugging purposes. To explain better, let's open the home page of Facebook. Once the page loads up, open up the Firebug panel and from the top menu of the panel, click the second button from the left, which reads 'Click an element in the page to inspect'. This enables the highlighter on the browser page; so use the mouse to highlight the section to be debugged and click the mouse button. Figure 2 demonstrates that the text reading 'Sign Up' was selected from the Facebook home page and was changed to 'Welcome'. As seen in that figure, the bottom left portion shows the exact HTML tag that was modified to achieve the result. On the right side of the panel, we can see the CSS code and tags which form that particular area of the page. This technique can be used for modifying any HTML tag, CSS styles, fonts, colours,

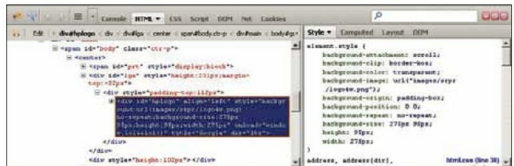


Figure 1: Sample dashboard



Figure 2: Sign Up changed to 'Welcome'